

Stalemate is different from mate

Foundations

THE IDEA

A player with no legal move is stalemated if the king is not in check. In standard chess this ends in a draw. Large material advantages do not change that rule, so careless checking-piece placement can throw away a win.

WORKED EXAMPLE

With Black's king on a8, White's king on c6, and White's queen on b6, Black to move has no legal move and is not checked. The a7, b7, and b8 escape squares are controlled.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

Why is the sample position a draw despite White's queen?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Black cannot move the king anywhere safely, but a8 itself is not attacked. There are no other black pieces to move. Those two facts distinguish stalemate from checkmate.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

When the opponent has few moves, check for stalemate before moving.